ASABA MEMORIAL HIGH SCHOOL

CHILD PROTECTION AND SAFEGUARDING POLICY

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Policy owner	**Asaba Memorial High School**
Responsible lead	**Headteacher / designated Child Protection Focal Person**
Approval authority	**Board of Governors (BOG), subject to applicable law**
Approved by: **Byamungu Bienvenu, Chairperson BOG**	
Date Approved	**07th April 2026**
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Review cycle	**At least every three years, or earlier if required**
Next review date	**07th April 2029**
Status	**APPROVED**

This policy applies to all school activities and school-related settings, including classrooms, dormitories, vocational/skilling activities, trips, sports, digital communications and activities involving visitors, contractors, volunteers or partner organizations.

1. POLICY STATEMENT AND COMMITMENT

Asaba Memorial High School (AMHS) is committed to providing a safe, respectful, inclusive and supportive learning environment in which every child is protected from abuse, neglect, exploitation, violence, discrimination and other forms of harm.

The school adopts a zero-tolerance approach to child abuse and exploitation. No educational objective, disciplinary concern, cultural practice, personal relationship, financial contribution or position of authority justifies harming a child. All adults associated with the school must act in the best interests of children and promptly report reasonable concerns.

This policy establishes minimum standards for prevention, identification, reporting, response and accountability. It is to be read together with applicable Ugandan law, Ministry of Education and Sports requirements, school rules, staff and student codes of conduct, and relevant AMEF policies where applicable.

2. PURPOSE AND OBJECTIVES

The objectives of this policy are to:

- prevent abuse, exploitation, neglect, bullying and other harm within school activities and school-related settings;
- set clear standards of behaviour for staff, school leaders, board members, learners, volunteers, visitors, contractors and partners;
- ensure children and adults know how to raise concerns safely and without fear of retaliation;
- provide clear, timely and child-centred procedures for responding to disclosures, allegations and incidents;
- ensure appropriate referral to statutory authorities and competent service providers where required;
- protect confidentiality while prioritising a child's safety and complying with legal reporting obligations;
- promote accountability, learning and continuous improvement in safeguarding practice.

3. SCOPE AND APPLICATION

This policy applies to all children enrolled at or participating in AMHS activities and to all persons acting for, representing or working with the school, whether paid or unpaid. This includes the Board of Governors, School Director/Founder, Headteacher, teaching and non-teaching staff, coaches, matrons/patrons, drivers, security personnel, volunteers, visitors, contractors, consultants, partner organisations and service providers.

It applies on school premises and during school-related activities, including dormitories, transport, school trips, sports, clubs, community outreach, vocational or practical training, online learning, social media and communication using personal or school devices. It also applies to concerns arising outside school where the concern may affect a learner's safety or the school's safeguarding responsibilities.

For this policy, a child is any person below 18 years of age. Where a learner is 18 or older, the school will still apply appropriate safeguarding, dignity, anti-harassment and duty-of-care measures.

4. LEGAL AND POLICY FRAMEWORK

This policy should be interpreted consistently with the Constitution of the Republic of Uganda, the The Children Act, Cap. 59 (as amended by the Children (Amendment) Act, 2016), the Education (Pre-Primary, Primary and Post-Primary) Act, Cap 121, applicable regulations and Ministry of Education and Sports guidance, laws relating to domestic violence and sexual offences, and applicable data-protection and privacy requirements.

The school shall comply with any mandatory reporting, referral, inspection and record-keeping obligations imposed by law. If this policy conflicts with applicable law, the law prevails. The school should periodically verify the current versions of relevant laws and Ministry guidance and update this policy accordingly.

5. DEFINITIONS

Child: Any person below 18 years of age.

Safeguarding: Actions taken to prevent harm to children, promote their welfare and respond appropriately to concerns.

Child abuse: An act or omission that causes, or is likely to cause, harm to a child. It may be physical, emotional, sexual or through neglect or exploitation.

Child protection concern: Any suspicion, allegation, disclosure, observation or information indicating that a child may be unsafe or harmed.

Disclosure: When a child or another person tells someone about possible abuse, exploitation or harm.

Designated Child Protection Focal Person (CPF): The person appointed by the Headteacher to receive concerns, coordinate safe internal action and support referrals. This role does not replace statutory authorities.

Retaliation: Punishing, intimidating, threatening, disadvantaging or mistreating a person because they raised a concern or participated in a safeguarding process.

6. GUIDING PRINCIPLES

- Best interests of the child: safety, dignity and welfare are primary considerations.
- Do no harm: all action must minimise the risk of further trauma, stigma or retaliation.
- Respect and non-discrimination: children must be treated fairly regardless of sex, disability, background, family circumstances, religion or other status.
- Child participation: children should be listened to and given age-appropriate information and choices wherever possible.
- Confidentiality and need-to-know sharing: information is shared only with people who need it to protect the child or meet legal duties.
- Accountability: every concern must be taken seriously and handled promptly, impartially and appropriately.
- Survivor-centred and child-sensitive response: the child must not be blamed, coerced or required to repeat their account unnecessarily.
- Fair process: allegations must be handled without prejudging the outcome, while immediate safety measures are taken where necessary.

7. FORMS OF ABUSE, EXPLOITATION AND HARM

- Physical abuse: hitting, kicking, shaking, burning, harmful restraint or any deliberate physical punishment or injury.
- Emotional or psychological abuse: humiliation, threats, intimidation, degrading language, rejection, persistent belittling or frightening a child.
- Sexual abuse or exploitation: sexual contact or activity with a child, grooming, sexual harassment, coercion, sexualised messaging, exploitation, or causing a child to view or participate in sexual activity. A child cannot consent to sexual activity with an adult.
- Neglect: failure to provide necessary care, supervision, protection, medical attention, food, shelter, hygiene or safe living conditions within a person's responsibility.
- Bullying and peer-on-peer harm: repeated intimidation, physical or verbal aggression, exclusion, cyberbullying, coercion, hazing or abuse between learners.
- Exploitation and harmful practices: trafficking, forced labour, transactional or exploitative relationships, harmful initiation practices, child marriage or other practices prohibited by law.
- Online harm: grooming, threats, harassment, extortion, sharing private images, inappropriate contact or exposure to harmful content.
- Discriminatory harm: targeting or excluding a child because of sex, disability, poverty, family status, ethnicity, religion or other characteristic.

8. EXPECTED CONDUCT AND PROHIBITED BEHAVIOUR

8.1 Expected conduct

- Treat every child with respect and communicate in a calm, age-appropriate and non-threatening manner.
- Maintain professional boundaries and use transparent, observable settings for interactions with children.
- Where practicable, ensure one-to-one meetings occur in a visible setting and follow school procedures.
- Use only authorised and appropriate forms of physical contact, taking account of safety, dignity and the child's comfort.
- Report concerns promptly to the Child Protection Focal Person or Headteacher; if either is implicated, report to the BOG Chairperson or an appropriate external authority.
- Obtain required permissions and follow school procedures for trips, transport, photographs, online contact and activities involving children.

8.2 Prohibited conduct

- Corporal punishment, assault, threats, humiliating punishment or degrading treatment.
- Sexual contact, sexualised communication, grooming or exploitation of a child.
- Requesting or accepting money, gifts, favours, labour or personal services in exchange for marks, discipline decisions, access, assistance or opportunities.
- Meeting a child secretly, arranging unauthorised private contact, or taking a child to a private location without authorisation and a legitimate safeguarding plan.
- Using personal social media or messaging to communicate privately with learners in ways that bypass school safeguards.
- Taking, storing or sharing a child's photograph, video or personal information without appropriate authorisation and safeguards.
- Disclosing a child's identity or case details to people who do not need to know.
- Suppressing, concealing, destroying or falsifying safeguarding information; intimidating a reporter; or retaliating against anyone who raises a concern.
- Engaging in discriminatory, exploitative or inappropriate relationships with learners or using authority for personal gain.

9. SAFE RECRUITMENT, INDUCTION AND SUPERVISION

- The school shall use proportionate, lawful and role-appropriate recruitment checks, including identity and qualification verification, reference checks and any legally available criminal or safeguarding checks.

- Recruitment and engagement decisions shall consider a person's suitability to work with children. Gaps or concerns in employment history should be explored appropriately.
- All new staff, volunteers and relevant contractors must receive this policy, sign the Code of Conduct and complete safeguarding induction before undertaking unsupervised duties with children.
- Staff must be informed how to recognise, document and report concerns and how to respond to a disclosure.
- School leaders shall provide supervision, clear reporting lines and periodic refresher training. A person under investigation may be subject to proportionate interim safeguards, including changes to duties, without assuming guilt.

10. SAFE SCHOOL ENVIRONMENT AND ACTIVITIES

10.1 Classrooms, dormitories and facilities

- The school shall maintain reasonable supervision arrangements in classrooms, dormitories, washrooms, changing areas, kitchens, workshops and other spaces where children may be vulnerable.
- Adults must respect privacy in sleeping, bathing and changing areas. Entry by staff must be for a legitimate reason and follow clear, age-appropriate procedures.
- Practical training, workshops, kitchens and vocational activities must include risk assessments, safe equipment use, supervision, protective equipment where needed and age-appropriate tasks.
- School premises and facilities should be reviewed for hazards, unsafe isolated areas, inadequate lighting, insecure access or other risks to children.
- Visitors must follow sign-in, identification, escort and conduct requirements. Visitors must not be left alone with children unless formally authorised and appropriately assessed.

10.2 Trips, transport, sports and events

- Activities outside normal school hours or premises must have prior approval, a named responsible adult, appropriate supervision ratios, emergency contacts and a risk assessment.
- Transport arrangements must identify authorised drivers, safe pick-up/drop-off points and procedures for delays, emergencies and missing learners.
- Overnight trips and residential activities must have clear sleeping, supervision, privacy and emergency arrangements.
- Any physical activity or sport must be conducted safely and without degrading, coercive or abusive practices.

10.3 Discipline and peer-on-peer concerns

Discipline must be fair, proportionate, non-violent and consistent with applicable law and school rules. Corporal punishment and degrading treatment are prohibited. Peer-on-peer concerns must be taken seriously; the school shall protect the affected child, assess the safety of all children involved, avoid forced reconciliation and refer serious matters appropriately.

11. REPORTING CONCERNS AND DISCLOSURES

11.1 Who must report

Every person covered by this policy must report any reasonable concern, suspicion, allegation, disclosure or observation of child abuse or risk of harm. Proof is not required before reporting. Staff must not conduct their own investigation or promise secrecy.

11.2 Internal reporting route

1. Report immediately, or as soon as safely possible, to the designated Child Protection Focal Person or Headteacher.
2. If the concern involves the Focal Person or Headteacher, report directly to the BOG Chairperson or another designated Board member who is not implicated.
3. If the concern involves the School Director/Founder, BOG Chairperson or another senior authority, report to an appropriate external statutory authority and, where safe, another independent Board member.
4. If a child is in immediate danger or requires urgent medical assistance, contact emergency services/police or the nearest competent health facility without waiting for internal approval.
5. Where a matter may constitute a criminal offence or requires statutory intervention, the school shall refer it to the relevant authorities and shall not obstruct or replace their work.

11.3 Responding to a disclosure

6. Stay calm, listen carefully and take the child seriously.
7. Thank the child for telling you and reassure them that the harm is not their fault.
8. Do not promise confidentiality; explain that information will be shared only with people who need to help keep them safe.
9. Do not ask leading questions, press for unnecessary details, confront the alleged perpetrator or ask the child to repeat the story to multiple people.
10. Record the child's words as accurately as possible, distinguish facts from opinion, and note the date, time, location and immediate safety needs.
11. Pass the concern promptly to the appropriate reporting person and keep the record secure.

12. RESPONSE, REFERRAL AND CASE MANAGEMENT

The Child Protection Focal Person or designated responsible officer shall coordinate the school's initial response, subject to conflicts of interest and legal requirements. The response should:

- assess immediate danger and take proportionate steps to protect the child and other children;
- arrange urgent medical attention or psychosocial support where needed;
- make referrals to police, probation and social welfare officers, health services, child helpline services or other competent authorities as appropriate;
- inform the parent or caregiver when safe and appropriate, unless doing so may increase risk, compromise an investigation or conflict with advice from competent authorities;
- preserve relevant records and evidence without conducting unauthorised searches or interviews;
- cooperate with statutory investigations and comply with lawful instructions;
- document decisions, referrals, actions, responsible persons and follow-up dates;
- consider appropriate interim protective measures, including supervised contact or temporary changes in duties, while respecting fairness and confidentiality;
- ensure follow-up to assess the child's safety, attendance, wellbeing and access to support.

The school shall not mediate or arrange private settlements of suspected sexual abuse, serious assault or other matters requiring statutory intervention. The child's safety and the applicable law take priority.

13. CONFIDENTIALITY, RECORDS AND DATA PROTECTION

- Safeguarding records must be factual, dated, legible and stored securely with access limited to authorised personnel.
- Information shall be shared on a strict need-to-know basis, subject to the child's safety and legal reporting duties.
- Records must not be stored in public areas, informal group chats or personal devices unless a secure and authorised process specifically permits it.
- Staff must not circulate names, photographs, allegations or case updates among colleagues, parents or community members who have no safeguarding role.
- Records shall be retained, transferred and disposed of in accordance with applicable law and the school's approved records-management arrangements.
- Any suspected loss, unauthorised access or disclosure of safeguarding information must be reported promptly to the Headteacher or other appropriate authority.

14. PHOTOGRAPHY, MEDIA AND DIGITAL SAFETY

- Obtain appropriate consent and follow school authorisation procedures before photographing, filming or publishing identifiable images of children, subject to legal and safeguarding requirements.
- Explain the intended use of images in an understandable manner. Consent must not be treated as permission to publish material that places a child at risk or undermines their dignity.
- Never publish images or details that identify a child as a victim or alleged victim of abuse, or that expose sensitive personal circumstances.
- School-approved digital channels should be used for learning-related communication. Adults must not send sexualised, threatening or secretive messages to learners or request private images.
- Report cyberbullying, grooming, threats, sextortion, unauthorised image sharing or other online safeguarding concerns promptly and preserve relevant evidence safely.

15. INCLUSION AND CHILDREN AT HEIGHTENED RISK

The school recognises that some children may face increased barriers to safety or reporting, including children with disabilities, children living in poverty, children without stable parental care, children experiencing violence at home, children affected by displacement, and children who face stigma or discrimination.

The school shall make reasonable efforts to provide accessible reporting channels, communication support, safe referrals and non-discriminatory treatment. No child shall be denied protection because of disability, gender, family circumstances, financial status or inability to communicate in a particular way.

16. ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

Role	Responsibilities
Board of Governors	Approve this policy; provide oversight; ensure safeguarding concerns involving senior leadership can be reported independently; review serious incidents and policy implementation; support adequate resources and accountability.
BOG Chairperson	Receive escalated concerns where senior school management is implicated, provided the Chairperson is not implicated; ensure an independent and lawful response; maintain appropriate confidentiality.

School Director/Founder	Support a safe school culture and adequate safeguarding resources; comply with this policy; avoid interfering with reports or investigations; exercise governance authority through the proper school structures.
Headteacher	Lead implementation; appoint/designate a Child Protection Focal Person; ensure staff induction, supervision, communication and safe reporting; act promptly on concerns; maintain secure records and report to the Board as appropriate.
Child Protection Focal Person	Receive and document concerns; assess immediate safety needs; coordinate referrals and follow-up; maintain confidential records; escalate conflicts of interest; not investigate criminal allegations independently.
Teachers and other staff	Maintain professional boundaries, supervise learners appropriately, report concerns promptly, cooperate with lawful processes and never retaliate against reporters.
Parents and caregivers	Support the child's safety, cooperate with appropriate school safeguarding actions and use designated channels to raise concerns, subject to the child's safety and applicable law.
Learners	Treat others respectfully, follow school safety rules, and tell a trusted adult when they or another child may be unsafe. Children are not responsible for investigating or resolving abuse.
Visitors, contractors and partners	Follow school safeguarding instructions, maintain boundaries, report concerns and accept appropriate restrictions on access to children.

17. TRAINING, COMMUNICATION AND AWARENESS

- The policy shall be explained to staff, learners, parents/caregivers and relevant partners in formats appropriate to their roles and ages.
- Staff and relevant volunteers shall receive induction and periodic refresher training on boundaries, reporting, disclosure response and referral procedures.

- The school shall display or communicate safe reporting contacts and child-friendly reporting guidance.
- The Headteacher shall ensure that relevant personnel know the current contact details for local police, health facilities, probation and social welfare services, and child protection services.

Uganda Child Helpline: 116. This number should be verified periodically before publication or use. In an emergency, contact the police or nearest competent emergency/health service.

18. BREACHES, DISCIPLINARY ACTION AND PROTECTION FROM RETALIATION

A breach of this policy may result in disciplinary action, restriction of duties, termination of engagement, referral to a professional regulator or statutory authority, or other lawful action, depending on the facts and applicable procedures. Any response shall be proportionate and shall not obstruct a criminal or statutory investigation.

No person may threaten, intimidate, punish or disadvantage a child, staff member or other person for raising a concern in good faith or cooperating with a safeguarding process. Deliberately malicious or knowingly false allegations may be addressed through fair procedures, but a concern must not be dismissed merely because it cannot be substantiated.

19. MONITORING, REVIEW AND APPROVAL

The Headteacher shall coordinate implementation and maintain records of staff induction, concerns received, referrals, actions taken, training and policy reviews. The Board of Governors shall provide oversight and review implementation at appropriate intervals while protecting confidentiality.

This policy shall be reviewed at least once every three years, and sooner following a serious incident, a change in law or Ministry guidance, a material change in school activities, or identification of a significant safeguarding gap.

This document is a submission draft and becomes the school's formally approved policy only after approval is recorded by the authorised governing body and the approval details below are completed.

ANNEX A: CHILD SAFEGUARDING CODE OF CONDUCT

Every person working for, volunteering with, governing or representing AMHS shall read and comply with this Code of Conduct.

I will:

- prioritise children's safety, dignity and best interests;
- treat all children respectfully and without discrimination;
- maintain professional boundaries and appropriate supervision;
- use authorised communication channels and follow procedures for images, trips, transport and one-to-one contact;
- report concerns, allegations and breaches promptly;
- respect confidentiality and keep safeguarding records secure;
- cooperate with lawful safeguarding and referral processes;
- challenge unsafe conduct where it is safe to do so and seek help when necessary.

I will not:

- use corporal punishment, humiliating language, threats or violence;
- engage in sexual, exploitative, secretive or inappropriate relationships or communications with a child;
- offer or accept favours, money or benefits in exchange for marks, access, silence or personal services;
- be alone with a child in an unauthorised private setting or take a child off-site without approval;
- take or share unauthorised images or personal information about a child;
- investigate allegations myself, promise secrecy, suppress a report or retaliate against a reporter.

Declaration: I have read and understood the AMHS Child Protection and Safeguarding Policy and agree to comply with it. I understand that a breach may lead to disciplinary or other lawful action.

Full name	_____
Role / organization	_____
Signature	_____
Date	_____

ANNEX B: CHILD PROTECTION CONCERN / INCIDENT REPORT FORM

Complete only what is known. Record facts, not assumptions. Do not investigate or ask leading questions. If a child is in immediate danger, seek urgent help first.

1. Date and time report received	_____
2. Name and role of person receiving report	_____
3. Child's name / identifier and age (if known)	_____
4. Safe contact / support needs (if appropriate)	_____
5. Date, time and location of alleged incident	_____
6. Nature of concern (tick/describe)	Physical / emotional / sexual abuse / neglect / bullying / online harm / other
7. What was seen, heard or disclosed?	
8. Exact words used by the child, where possible	
9. Immediate safety or medical needs	
10. Person(s) alleged to be involved (if known)	_____
11. Immediate action taken and by whom	_____
12. Referral made (agency, person, date/time)	_____
13. Parent/caregiver informed? If not, why?	_____
14. Follow-up action, responsible person and date	_____

15. Signature of reporting person	_____
16. Focal Person / authorized officer review	Name: Signature: _____ Date: _____

ANNEX C: CHILD-FRIENDLY REPORTING GUIDANCE

If something happens that makes you feel unsafe, scared, uncomfortable or confused, you can tell a trusted adult at school. You can speak to a teacher, the Headteacher, the Child Protection Focal Person or another adult you trust.

- You will be listened to and treated respectfully.
- You are not to blame for abuse or harm done to you.
- The adult may need to tell people who can help keep you safe. They should not share your story with people who do not need to know.
- If the first person does not help, tell another trusted adult or contact a child protection service.
- If you or another child is in immediate danger, seek help straight away.